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What Does a User Interface (UI) Designer Do? Role Explained

Written by Coursera Staff • Updated on Mar 18, 2026
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A UI designer creates visually appealing, user-friendly interfaces for apps, websites, and devices. This guide covers their role, key skills, qualifications, and steps to start a career in UI design focused on intuitive navigation and user experience.



Key takeaways

UI designers are professionals who create and optimize visual and interactive elements for apps, websites, and devices.

- The estimated median total pay for UI designers is $115,000 [1].
- UI design techniques utilize typography, color theory, prototyping, wireframes, breadcrumbs, and accessibility.

- You can take steps toward becoming a UI designer by gaining UI design skills, gaining experience, building your portfolio, and networking.

Learn more about this career path, including responsibilities, qualifications, and how to land your first UI design role. If you're ready to start gaining the skills you need to apply, consider enrolling in the Google UX Design Professional Certificate program. In as little as six months, you could gain in-demand UI and UX design skills like prototyping, wire framing, and usability testing.



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What is a UI designer?

A UI designer is a tech professional who designs the graphical user interface (GUI) of an app, website, or device. For example, when you access a website or an app on your phone, the user interface includes

everything you can see that allows you to navigate and achieve your goal. UI designers create and optimize the interactive elements that facilitate your actions, such as buttons, menus, breadcrumbs, progress bars, and accordions.

Why is visual design important?

Creating visually pleasing interfaces is important, but UI extends beyond the aesthetic. When you're using an app or website, it should be intuitive, meaning that you have a good idea of what will happen if you click a button or flip a toggle switch. UI designers use visual cues to help guide a user through the interface.

A site or app should also be accessible and inclusive. Users should be able to operate and understand the interface regardless of their ability, age, race, gender identity, or background. This might mean choosing a font that's easy to read and translatable into different languages or selecting colors that colorblind users can differentiate.

Essential terms in UI design

In researching UI design, you may come across important terms specific to this field. Here are a few terms to familiarize yourself with so that you can deepen your understanding of UI design and make an empowered decision about starting a career as a UI designer.

Term	Definition
User interface	The means by which a person interacts with an application or hardware device
Typography	The style and appearance of written material; the art of making type legible, readable, and appealing
Color theory	A series of concepts and guiding principles for the visual design of colors and how they mix, match, and contrast
Prototype	A sample or simulation of a final product used to test and gather feedback
Wireframe	A layout displaying functional elements of an interface
Breadcrumb	A way to show website users where they are in a website hierarchy (and how they got there)
Accessibility	The concept of whether a service or product can be used by people of all abilities, irrespective of their situation
Affordance	A feature or property of an element that helps a user understand how they can interact with it

What does a UI designer do?

As a UI designer, you'll be tasked with designing what digital products look like and how users will interact with them. According to Zippia's research on real UI designer resumes, tasks and decisions you might be responsible for include [2]:

- Testing new designs on mobile and desktop

- Managing prototype content in wireframes
- Instructing teams on low-fidelity and high-fidelity prototyping
- Making style guides for design consistency across screens
- Translating business requirements to functional UI design
- Collaborating with UX designers, development teams, and product teams
- Designing layouts for e-commerce websites and interactive websites

Additional duties might include:

- Ensuring designs can adapt to multiple device types (responsive design)
- Improving and modernizing existing design environments
- Visualizing interactive elements, like buttons, sliders, toggles, icons, drop-down menus, and text fields
- Choosing color palettes, fonts, and typesetting
- Communicating with developers to make sure features are implemented as intended
- Analyzing the impact of design and usability changes
- Creating wireframes or high-fidelity (hi-fi) layouts to show what an interface looks like with visual elements and branding included

“A big part of being a UI designer is that you are part of a team,” says Michael Worthington, founding partner of L.A. design studio Counterspace and faculty member at the California Institute of the Arts. “Your creative solutions have to work in concert with a lot of other concerns from other team members: back-end issues, marketing strategies, UX feedback, etc. When your work gets better from these interactions is when teamwork is really working.”

Skills needed in UI design

As a UI designer, you’ll take your creativity into a digital environment and use technical skills to translate your ideas onto the screen. Effective UI designers rely on a broad skill set. Chances are you already possess some of these key skills.

- **Empathy:** Creating a product that’s easy and intuitive often means seeing things from a user’s perspective. If you can empathize with the people who’ll eventually use your designs, you can begin to tailor your design decisions to their needs.
- **Collaboration:** Product development is a team effort. You’ll likely work closely with UX designers and user researchers to transform their basic wireframes and information architectures into fully designed prototypes. You’ll also work with front-end developers to translate your designs into functional code. Sometimes you may also be asked to present your designs to stakeholders.

- **Design and prototyping tools:** The exact tools you use may vary depending on the company you work for, the product you're designing, or your own personal preference. Some popular UI design tools you may want to familiarize yourself with include Sketch, Figma, InVision, Balsamiq, Axure, and Adobe XD.
- **Color theory:** Some of the most important choices you'll make as a UI designer regard colors and color palettes. This isn't just about what looks good. Colors can also hint at function and support brand identity.
- **Typography:** Typography plays a key role in UI design and can even make the difference between good UI and bad UI.
- **Design patterns:** UI design patterns offer general solutions to common design problems. Familiarity with these common patterns and components will save you time and allow you to focus on more specific user problems.

UI vs. UX design

User experience (UX) and user interface (UI) design often go hand in hand, but the two fields have some important differences. While UX encompasses the overall experience a user has with a product or service, UI focuses on the graphic design and interface.



Why pursue a career in UI design

If you're passionate about design and interested in product development and web design work, then a career in UI could be a good fit. Working in this field gives you the opportunity to work in a collaborative environment to create solutions to real-world problems.

"UI design offers a career that mixes the practical and the creative," says Worthington. "Creative problem solving keeps your brain active and engaged, and frankly makes work enjoyable. For me, a career where you can be creatively fulfilled and be paid for your work is the best reward."

> *For me, a career where you can be creatively fulfilled and be paid for your work is the best reward.*

UI designer salary and job outlook

According to Glassdoor, the estimated median total pay for UI designers is $115,000 as of March 2026 [1]. This figure includes base salary and additional pay, which may represent profit-sharing, commissions, bonuses, or other compensation. This figure is an estimate of a UI designer's total pay, including base pay and additional pay like tips, commissions, and profit sharing.

While user interfaces have been around for as long as we've had machines and computers, the role of UI designer is relatively new (and quickly growing). According to the US Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), jobs in the web development and digital design industry are projected to grow 7 percent between 2024 and 2034, which is faster than average [3].

4 steps to becoming a UI designer

There are many paths toward working as a UI designer. The process may vary based on your experience, education, transferable skills, and the type of company you're hoping to work for. Let's look at a few steps you can take to set yourself up for success.

1. Learn UI design skills.

A career in UI/UX design starts with having the right skills. While not always required to get a job, earning a degree is one way to start building your skillset. Some universities offer degree programs in human-computer interaction, human-centered computing, or human-centered design. Degrees or coursework in web design, digital design, and graphic arts often target skills that overlap with UI design.

Another option is to take courses or attend boot camps that specialize in UI design. Look for programs that give you hands-on experience with common UI tools so you can put what you're learning into practice.

For example, if you're looking to build your knowledge of accessibility in design, you can master accessibility-first CSS styling in as little as two hours with the online Guided Project, Introduction to Accessible Web Development. You'll obtain expert guidance to create an accessible custom component using ARIA and earn a shareable certificate once you complete the course.

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“Think about what role in UI you want to have and build your strengths in that area,” advises Worthington. “Are you a hands-on UI (graphic) designer? Do you specialize in organization and structure, strategy, branding, and overlap more with UX? Play to your strengths and shore up your weaknesses.”

2. Gain experience.

"After learning a few basics, try to work on a real project as soon as possible," recommends Roman Jaster, visiting faculty at the California Institute of the Arts. "Student projects are great (and really valuable for learning basic techniques), but projects 'in the wild' have one important addition: actual users—you know, the U in the UX."

> *After learning a few basics, try to work on a real project as soon as possible.*

You don’t need to wait until you get hired to start gaining experience, either. Start by working on the design of your own website, or see if any family or friends have sites or apps that could use a redesign. Pay attention to the design of pages or apps you use regularly, and think about how you could improve the UI.

If you’re working toward a degree, check with your school’s career services office for any internship opportunities. Alternatively, you could volunteer your design services for local schools or non-profit organizations.

As you gain experience, focus on learning the software common to UI jobs.

“Right now, fluency with Figma will really help you visualize your ideas and fit right into a work environment,” says Worthington, “but it's important to remember that whatever software you are using is just a tool. The expertise you bring in how you use the tool is even more important: graphic design skills, creative thinking, and imagination should form the backbone of your skill set.”

> *Graphic design skills, creative thinking, and imagination should form the backbone of your skill set.*

3. Build your portfolio.

Your portfolio is perhaps the most important factor when applying for UI jobs. More than anything else, your body of work demonstrates to potential employers what you can do. You don’t necessarily need your own website to have a portfolio. Online portfolio platforms like Dribbble, Behance, or Coroflot offer a free and convenient place to showcase your designs.

As you gain experience, remember to update your portfolio with your newest and best work.

4. Expand your network.

While many designers find out about open positions through public job boards, it's also possible to find opportunities directly from your network. Start building relationships with other project development professionals (including UX designers and web developers) by attending industry events or interacting online. You never know who you might meet or what doors those relationships might open.

Read more: UX Design Books, Blogs, and Podcasts: A Resource List

Explore our free resources for graphic design professionals

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- **Watch on YouTube:** UI vs. UX: Choosing Your Design Career Path
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